employment is also anticipated in rural regions. Around 5 lakh people are expected to secure employment directly or indirectly from the 18 Krushi Samruddhi Kendras.

The MSRDC has also created a record of sorts by seamlessly acquiring 20,000 acres of land within a span of just one year (92% by mutual consent). A total of 8861.02-hectare land for the 120 meter wide Right of Way (RoW) at the plain section and 90 meter wide RoW in the forest section was accomplished for the entire 701km length. All land was purchased through direct purchasing with the consent of farmers. The MSRDC gave maximum compensation to farmers at the rate of 5 times the ready reckoner rates for their lands.

Already Rs. 7,997.97 crore stands disbursed to farmers in compensation for the expressway project. The cost of the mega project is pegged at Rs.55,335 crore with a debt burden of Rs.28,000 crore. The funds were raised from the State Bank of India (SBI) and other banks on loan basis. Assistance was also taken from the MHADA, CIDCO, SRA, MMRDA, MIDC and the State Government of Maharashtra. A series of discussions, presentations were held with banks by MSRDC to enthuse investor confidence. The MSRDC is appreciative of the SBI, MHADA, CIDCO, SRA, MMRDA, MIDC and the State Government of Maharashtra for providing funds to the Expressway.

The MSRDC finalized the greenfield alignment assimilating the best option considering topography, background of surrounding areas, importance of the nearby districts and cities, i.e., industries, historical, political, administrative importance,



while also taking into consideration road crossings and connectivity to the proposed Expressway. 5 DPR consultants comprising experts, designers, engineers and technicians were then appointed to prepare the Detailed Project Report (DPR).

The project factored in all necessary environmental and forest clearances since it directly passes through 10 districts, 26 talukas and 392 villages in addition to 14 districts that lie in its vicinity. The Expressway boasts of 25 exit and entry points (interchanges). This project is the first one where, at the planning stage itself, the concerns of the wildlife habitat were addressed in partnership with the Wildlife Institute of India.

The Expressway is the shortest route connecting two major metropolitan cities – Mumbai and Nagpur, i.e. capital and winter capital of Maharashtra. It joins Marathwada, Vidarbha and Western Maharashtra. As the Expressway is designed for speeds of 150km per hour (currently permissible speeds @ 120 km per hour), the travel time between Nagpur to Mumbai stands reduced to 8 hours. This is expected to dramatically boost the economy of the people staying along its length. The commercial movement (rail freight corridor) will link JNPT, Mumbai and proposed Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Expressway.

The Expressway will greatly enhance tourism potential of the entire region as well the Ajanta, Verul caves, Lonar lake and the Tadoba National Park, Shirdi Saibaba pilgrimage center, Igatpuri Hill Station, etc. Essentially, the Expressway will spell out the successful solidarity for citizens of Vidarbha and Marathwada through quick road connectivity.

